Cry

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Cry

by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

Shadow Weaver has just lost someone dear to her, yet refuses to cry.

Castaspella, on the other hand, refuses to let her hide the pain away.

Will the woman let go of her prejudices and allow herself just a moment of grief?

Notes

This one-shot is fully cathartic for me.

More in the ending notes

See the end of the work for more notes

It was a busy Monday at the office. Phones rang, people walked around carrying papers, or yelled from one desk to another asking for information or supplies they needed as soon as possible.

Yet in the middle of that chaos, Castaspella could see Shadow Weaver slowly drinking her cup of coffee.

The woman seemed disconnected from everything. There was something wrong, and she knew exactly what. But it seemed like Shadow Weaver refused to acknowledge it.

Perhaps she needed a little bump…

—Hey, Bea— Castaspella began, gentle, approaching her from the right. —What are you doing here?

—Working… Normally that's why I come to the office.

—I mean, why did you come today?

—Still the same answer. I am working— Shadow Weaver insisted, starting to get annoyed already.

—You should stay at home if you don't feel well…

—Who says I am unwell?— she asked, now looking back at Castaspella.

—I can see that— she simply replied, briefly glancing away.

—Then you're seeing things, woman.

—Bea…

—That's enough, go back to work.

—Please don't force yourself…

—Es…— Shadow Weaver let out, with a warning tone.

—You are allowed to be sad and grieving— Castaspella insisted, placing a hand on her shoulder.

—Enough!— the woman finally exclaimed. Putting the cup down on the table rather forcefully, she grabbed her by the arm to pull her into the break room. As she let go of her, slamming the door shut, she angrily questioned her —Why are you doing this!? I'm not sad or grieving! I'm *fine*!

—It's just the first week, you're bound to…

—I'm *not* crying!

—You loved him! It's normal to cry! He passed barely last Friday!

—I don't want to cry! I don't *need* to cry! Crying is for the *weak*!

—My love, please…

—Forget it and leave me alone!

—I won't. Not now. Not like this.

—Why do you *insist*!? Why do you *want* to see me cry!?

—I just want you to let yourself express this pain you're feeling. Please…

—I'm feeling *nothing*.

—That's not true. I can see it in your expression, you're grieving but won't accept it.

—I don't need grieving! I need to return to my desk! Let me go!

—I'm not even stopping you— she quickly pointed out. —But you haven't left because you *know* you don't really want to— Castaspella defied her.

—Why won't you give up, Esmeralda!? I don't want to… to…— Shadow Weaver exclaimed, raising her voice for a moment before trailing off.

—You're not weak for crying for someone you love…— she interrupted, cupping her face with one hand as she could have sworn there were a few tears forming in her eyes.

—Just quit pitying me… P-please…

—It's not pity, I promise, Bea.

—Then what is it!?

—I love you. I just want to see you heal from this. And for that, you must let yourself cry, grieve as much as you need— Castaspella insisted, pulling her into a hug. —When do you receive his ashes?

—Next week…

—Why don't I help you put up a small altar for him, eh?

Shadow Weaver pulled back, kept her sight away, refusing to look at Castaspella, and took a deep breath, still making an effort to hold back her tears.

—If I agree, will you stop pestering me?

—Fine— she giggled.

—Regardless, I can't take a day off for this, alright?— she pointed out, letting out a sigh.

—You never take days off; why not now?

—I need to keep myself occupied. Whenever I'm not distracted with something, I start thinking about him, noticing his absence… It-it *hurts* to be at home now… Alone— she admitted. —And before you suggest staying at my place, it still isn't the same.

—I know it's not the same, but if you do need the company, don't hesitate to call me, alright?— Castaspella offered, smiling.

—I will.

By the end of the week, she had stayed at Shadow Weaver's place almost every night.

And the woman finally cried.

At night, only when she thought Castaspella was asleep already, but it was something.

She knew Shadow Weaver wouldn't do so if she knew she wasn't really asleep, so she'd just keep silent for a while and then pretend to turn in her sleep to hug her. Like that, her silent weeping would eventually calm down, and the woman would fall asleep, albeit not deeply.

In the morning, Castaspella would put extra care into preparing breakfast for her, she'd try to make conversation every time Shadow Weaver's expression went gloomy, and continue to keep her "distracted" as she wanted throughout the day.

The following Monday, she woke up the woman with a small gift.

—Good morning— Castaspella gently said, giving her a kiss on the forehead.

Shadow Weaver brushed her eyes a few times and finally saw the small thing in front of her.

—What is this?

—A little something for you.

—I don't need any gifts…

—I just wanted to give you this. It's… for the altar we talked about— she finally revealed, to convince her to open it.

Curious yet hesitant, Shadow Weaver accepted the present and carefully unwrapped it: a silver frame. Under the glass, there was a picture of a cute black cat peeking from behind a curtain, its mismatched eyes staring directly into the camera.

A single tear fell on the frame as Shadow Weaver's hands started to tremble.

—You didn't have to— the woman uttered, her voice broken. —It's beautiful— she said, looking up at Castaspella with her eyes full of tears.

Smiling gently, she leant forward to briefly kiss Shadow Weaver, and took a moment to caress her cheek.

—You can always change the picture if you have a better one.

—N-no, no. This one is perfect— she assured her. The woman sniffed and brushed away the tears that managed to fall down her cheeks, then pressed her lips together to hold back a sob. —I can't believe you did this to me— she let out, with a breathless laugh.

—Don't say it as if it were something bad— Castaspella complained, her tone light-hearted.

The women stayed silent for a moment, faint smiles on their faces as Shadow Weaver stared at the frame, until they heard their stomachs grumble and laughed together.

—I'll leave this here until I get the ashes— she decided, placing it on her nightstand. —We should get breakfast now.

—Well, it's a bit late so we better get going and pass by the coffee shop— Castaspella suggested, after checking her phone.

Two days later, right after Shadow Weaver arrived home, a courier showed up with a letter and a wooden box with a small plate bearing the name: Shadow.

She felt numb when receiving it. After shutting the door, she returned to the living room and put the box and the letter down on the table.

On the outside, she looked calm, but on the inside, she was panicking.

—Pick up, pick up, pick up…— she muttered, holding the phone to her ear. —Es!— she exclaimed, as soon as she heard her answer on the other side. —The-the ashes arrived. I-I don't know what to do now… I know it's late but… Would you come over? I-I don't think I can wait until tomorrow. I can't… handle this— she admitted, making a huge effort to hold back her tears. —Tha-thank you.

And barely twenty minutes later, Castaspella showed up at the door with a bag.

—I brought food. We'll handle that and then have dinner, alright?

—I don't think I can eat now— Shadow Weaver replied, looking away while letting her walk in.

—I imagine, but you need to eat something, Bea. At least a bit.

—Thank you— she sighed, smiling faintly.

—What is it?— Castaspella asked, concerned.

—I… don't think I can do this— Shadow Weaver seriously said, as the women sat at the table, thinking about how to put together the famous altar. —I can't just have this here. His absence is already enough of a reminder. I can't also have his ashes here!

—Bea, calm down. It's… I know it will hurt every time you see it, but like this, he's always with you, even now— Castaspella tried to soothe her.

—No, no. I-I like the idea of the altar but I can't have it here…

—What do you mean?

—Can't we just… do it at your place, maybe?

—Bea…

—Please…

Castaspella stood up and walked around the table to hug her from behind.

—I know it hurts, but it should be here. He was your baby, you will always miss him. And I'm sure he would have wanted to stay here with you— she gently told her.

—But…

—I know— she sighed, kissing Shadow Weaver's head. —Just, trust me, yes? We'll find a good place for it.

—Where?

—Let me see… I'll check your room for a moment, perhaps there's a good place there— she decided, and walked away. The woman didn't answer, just stayed there, sitting in front of the table, looking at the box. By the time Castaspella walked back into the living room, she found a scene that froze her for a second. Shadow Weaver was now sitting on the couch, the wooden box on her lap, and her hand absentmindedly caressing its top. —Bea?— she gently called, approaching. That was when Castaspella noticed the tears wetting her face, and immediately knelt in front of her. —My love…

About an hour later, when Shadow Weaver had shed more than enough tears, she gently guided the woman to her room and showed her an empty space on one of her bookshelves.

—Why there?

—I remember he loved high places, and usually slept among your books, so… I thought…

—I see…— she sighed. —It's perfect— she admitted, giving Castaspella a sad smile.

—Let's do it like this, then— she stated, gently taking the wooden box from between her hands. However, before setting it on the shelf, she stopped and considered —The box is… well, it looks perfect to be painted… Do you want to decorate it in any way?

—I wouldn't know how…— Shadow Weaver admitted. —If you have any ideas, I'll listen.

—It should be something special for you. Perhaps there's something he liked that you could paint on the box…— she suggested.

—I don't know, Es. I have no idea right now.

—Don't rush it. You can do it at any given moment— Castaspella replied, smiling gently. —For now, we'll settle this here. And… the frame on top. What do you say?

The woman stared at the "altar" for a moment, tears forming in her eyes again, and finally sighed —It's… nice.

—We can do something better if you want. Oh! And, look! I brought you this.

From a pocket, Castaspella produced a little packet of perfumed Dhoop Sticks, and placed it next to the wooden box.

—What is that?

—Just some incense sticks. You can light one for him on his birthday... Or whenever you want— she explained.

—I- Yes, I have quite a selection of incense myself, but… I wasn't expecting… Ne-nevermind.

—I suppose that was silly of me— Castaspella suddenly said, lowering her head. —You'd probably prefer burning bikhur…

—Your Dhoop Sticks are more than fine— Shadow Weaver quickly told her, reaching for her chin and gently tilting her head up. —Thank you.

She smiled back at the woman and giggled contentedly as she stepped forward. After a moment of just looking at each other, the women took a second to share a kiss and stayed in each other's arms for a while.

Eventually, Castaspella asked —Would you like to eat now? I brought your favourite food…

—Oh, is it? Then I better open a good bottle of wine for that— Shadow Weaver teasingly said. —Thank you, Es…

As a reply, she only leant on the woman and let out a sigh.

They walked out of the room together, turned off the lights, and prepared everything for their dinner.

—What's on your mind?— Castaspella gently asked, noticing Shadow Weaver's expression once the food was gone.

—Sometimes… I feel like he's still around, just, sitting in silence, sleeping, like he used to…— she admitted, after a moment. —He was just… so quiet. Whenever he hid, or even if he wasn't hiding but rather just sitting at an unusual place, it would take me so long to find him… all because he wouldn't meow at me when I called…— she went on. Castaspella leant forward on the table, interested, and let her continue. —I think that only makes it worse… The feeling, I mean. Because it's like… like he's still here, until I remember he's not and… it hits worse than anything— she explained. —I… I think… I don't know… Perhaps I should just… forget about Shadow?

—Bea…— Castaspella immediately called, extending a hand over the table to reach the woman. —Don't start talking nonsense now. Why would you have to forget him?

—It's the only way to stop suffering— she let out between her teeth. —Don't you understand? I can't bear this, Es…

Letting out a sigh, Castaspella stood up, walked around the table, and knelt next to Shadow Weaver.

—Hey, listen to me: you *can* bear this. Of course you can, my Love. Now it feels impossible because you're just starting to deal with this, but… it won't always feel like now. It will become

easier with time.

—You mean I will start forgetting… so why not forget him now and be done with this?— the woman hissed, never looking back at her.

—No, no. I don't mean that. Bea, look at me— she quickly replied. As Shadow Weaver refused to look back, she reached for her face and cupped her cheek before gently pulling to make the woman look her way. —You will never forget. Even if your memory fails, you will never forget him— she assured her. —What I mean is… this is painful. Everyone tells you it will be, but that's nothing like actually experiencing that pain. Nothing can prepare you for losing someone you love; you will never be ready for it. However, with time, you grow used to that heartache, so it later feels like… numb.

—You should stop trying, Es… just let me wallow in grief until I disappear.

—Of course not.

—Why?

—I told you, you fool… I love you. I won't abandon you; not now, not like this.

—Since you helped me with all the studies and other vet stuff, I suppose it is a bit too late to back down now, eh?— Shadow Weaver joked, with half a smile.

—You could say so— Castaspella replied, with the same tone.

—It's all so fresh on my memory. It feels like only yesterday we were struggling to make him stay still for the radiography…— the woman reminisced.

—It really does…

—I… Thanks again, Es. For… always being there— she finally sighed. —And for… not mocking me.

—Why would I mock you?

—Why wouldn't you? I must look pathetic, all undone, crying for a small animal I *knew* would die…

—That's not pathetic, Bea.

—It is…

—No, no. Beatrix, listen to me: you're not pathetic for having *feelings*! Normal, human- well, not human, let's say mortal feelings…

—Well, I don't want them— Shadow Weaver hissed, closing her fists tightly.

—But you have them. Just accept them, it will be better for you.

—Why? And how can I!? This… it's so… I don't even know how to put it!

—I understand. But, feelings aren't a bad thing— Castaspella argued. —Do you think my love for you is a bad thing?

—Of course not. I do think it's a bit…— Shadow Weaver began, until she gave her a warning look. —Silly. But I suppose it's not bad. I just don't like the *bad* feelings.

—I realize, but you can't choose what feelings to have. And if you don't think my love for you is bad, why are you considering your love for him bad?

—It is the grief that I consider bad…

—But it comes from *love*. You wouldn't feel sadness for losing him if you didn't love him…

—Just forget this…

Another week passed, Saturday arrived, and Shadow Weaver went to visit an old friend…

—Oh, Deary… I heard the bad news, I'm so sorry…

—I- Ye-yes. Who-who told you, Madam Razz?— the woman asked, curious and confused, ignoring the lump in her throat.

—Oh, Castaspella deary told me— she replied, noticeably sad. She then produced a folded sheet of paper and opened it. —Here, I wrote this for you— she said, giving it to Shadow Weaver. —I was so hurt to know the little one passed…

The woman took a moment to read through the short poem-like text. It was exactly what you'd expect from Madam Razz, and it broke her resolve not to cry. It was beautiful…

—Thank you— she finally uttered, and pressed her lips tightly to hold back a sob.

—He was such a lovely kitten. I imagine you miss him a lot, Deary.

—I do— she sighed.

—Don't worry, Deary. He's now in cat's heaven. He's watching over you— Razz assured her. —And he is here— she added, pointing at Shadow Weaver's chest. —Never forget it.

The woman was stunned for a moment, her eyes still wet from what she read, and barely managed to mutter —I… won't.

It was about to be a month since the little cat's passing, and Shadow Weaver's place was a real mess…

—Come on, just tell me where you left the bucket and I'll do the rest— Castaspella begged.

—Of course not, you've already cleaned enough…

—But if you're not feeling well or in the mood to clean, why not let me do it?

—I *can* do it… I just… don't want to now…

The woman looked down with a somber expression, and Castaspella completely understood.

—Look, cleaning is taxing and you're already running on low energy. I'm not pitying you, I just want to help— she gently explained, sitting on the couch next to her.

Shadow Weaver closed her eyes and let out a sigh as she leant back.

—Do you know what's the most difficult part of cleaning? Why I *really* can't clean in full earnest? — she asked, and then opened her eyes again to look at Castaspella. When she shook her head, the woman revealed —The hardest part… is feeling like I'm… erasing the last traces of Shadow. From the hairs he shed, to the little whiskers he lost; the stains from when we gave him his medicine, the little stones he would kick out of his litter tray… I can go on all day.

—Bea… He won't be erased so easily— Castaspella confidently said, before giving her a kiss on the cheek. —The traces he left in your heart won't disappear just because every last hair of his is gone from the house…

—But what if I *don't want* his every hair gone!?

—Then we don't clean it all— she concluded.

—You were just…

—I know what I said, but I mean… Re-remember that time one of his whiskers fell on me and I said I'd save it?

—You didn't…

—I did!— Castaspella smiled, taking out her wallet. —I kept it here and then forgot I had it, I won't lie. I only remember it when I'm about to pay for something— she laughed. —Doesn't it feel like a flexible needle?— she commented, with a chuckle.

—Sometimes I question your sanity…

—Hey!

—…But that doesn't mean I don't appreciate your craziness— the woman completed, smiling faintly. —Save it. It's enough for me to know that you have it. He really liked you too.

With a small smile, Castaspella put her wallet away and then rested on Shadow Weaver's shoulder.

—We'll manage the cleaning thing eventually… Now, why don't you tell me what else is on your mind?

—What makes you think I have something on my mind?

—Your leg is shaking— she replied, carefully resting a hand on top of Shadow Weaver's left knee, which was imperceptibly shaking up and down.

—How did you even…

—Bea…

—Alright. I- Listen, I don't feel that comfortable discussing this but I've been asked a few times about it, so I feel like maybe I have to discuss it with you— she began, noticeably nervous. —It hasn't been a month yet, but do you think it would be better for me to… adopt another cat?

Already?

Castaspella was sure she'd never think about this on her own when the loss of Shadow still pains her, but she did mention she was *asked* about it…

—Who asked you?

With a sigh, and rolling her eyes a bit, the woman replied —My psychologist, my psychiatrist, the driver who took me to visit Madam Razz…

—I see. But, do you *want* to bring in a new pet already?

—I don't know. Although they have asked me that question, I have been hesitant to ask myself the same.

—And why do you feel like you have to discuss it with me?— Castaspella gently asked.

—I don't know. You understand how feelings work a lot better than me.

—I see— she chuckled. —Then… let's think about it. Do you feel ready to bring another animal in here?

—I don't know about "ready". What I am, is… alone. I am not used to being alone in this house— she explained. —It may not seem like it, because he was really silent and didn't do much, but he truly kept me company. He would come to sit on my lap and sleep there for hours… He would wake me up by meowing loudly when he didn't have enough food, or pretend to be offended whenever I left him here alone to stay at your place. He would… sit nearby keeping me company, sleeping and making little sounds when he was dreaming something…— she elaborated. —I am *alone*, Es. Maybe not ready, but I'm sure alone.

On the brink of tears, she wrapped her arms around Shadow Weaver and hugged her gently.

—I understand, my Love.

With a defeated expression, the woman rested her head on top of Castaspella's and let out a deep sigh with her eyes closed.

—Perhaps I need more time to be ready…

—Perhaps, yes. But, if you ever brought another animal…

—Cat…

—Another cat…— Castaspella corrected, without raising her head. —What would you call it? Shadowy? Shadow the Second?— she proposed, laughing.

—Light.

—Huh?— she let out, confused, looking up at the woman.

—Either that or "Shadow" in another language— she seriously replied.

Castaspella let out a faint smile and sighed as she rested back on Shadow Weaver's shoulder.

—I see…

—But I definitely don't know if it's time to bring a new cat…— she sighed. —Even after all this time, whenever my mind isn't busy with something, if I close my eyes I see once again the moment after he was injected with the euthanasic… How I couldn't stop caressing him even after he… passed.

—I remember— Castaspella admitted, looking down and reaching for the woman's hand. She held it between hers as she recalled —You spent about ten minutes with him just caressing him and didn't want to leave the room. You said you didn't want to leave him alone.

They both shed silent tears for a moment, holding onto each other's hands like the day it happened.

—Why is it so hard?— Shadow Weaver eventually let out. —Why can't I just get over it?— she insisted, looking up at her with a pleading look. —I can't look at pictures of him without… without feeling like I'm choking. Whenever the screensaver of my computer activates, the photos of him appear and I just… I feel this lump in my throat… Why can't I just remember him without pain?

—Love, this is still too fresh. You just said it: It hasn't been a month yet— Castaspella reminded her. —The time will come when you'll think of the good memories with him and smile instead. Take your time to process your grief and don't try to rush through it. Let the process take as much time as necessary, alright?

—But…— the woman began, holding her hands tighter. —It's too difficult!

—I know— she replied, pulling her closer and resting her forehead against Shadow Weaver's. —I know…

The following Sunday, Castaspella didn't even ask; she tagged along and went to the woman's place with her.

That night, just a bit after midnight, it would be a month since Shadow's passing.

—You didn't have to come.

—I wanted to— she assured her, stepping into the house.

—Why?

—If you don't want me here…

—I do. But… why would you want to be here?— Shadow Weaver asked, her expression tired.

—I don't want to leave you alone— she replied, shy. Blushing a bit, she admitted —I actually don't want to leave you alone ever… But I don't suppose we're quite there yet…

—I disagree.

—Huh?— Castaspella let out, confused as she looked back at the woman.

—I think the real issue is neither of us would give up our place— she chuckled. —And I can't blame you, I wouldn't give up living in a mansion either— Shadow Weaver added.

—And I wouldn't force you to live in such a traditional place either when you're not used to it— she accepted, awkwardly scratching the back of her neck. —But then… should I consider this a formal invitation to live together?

—Maybe— the woman smirked, pulling her closer and walking backwards until she could sit on the couch. She had Castaspella sit on her lap and kissed her briefly before clarifying —I would have discussed this with you a lot earlier if it weren't for that… little detail.

—Yeah, I suppose it makes sense— she sighed.

—What would you like for dinner?— Shadow Weaver decided to ask.

—You mentioned the new place that opened next door… Why don't we try ordering some food?

—Saves me from cooking. Sounds great— she admitted, letting out a laugh.

With dinner arranged, the woman went to the kitchen, poured herself a glass of wine, and served Castaspella a shot glass of sake. Food arrived quite fast and they decided to eat on the bed, watching a movie.

That way, they were distracted until midnight…

—Let me take this to the kitchen— Castaspella decided, picking up the tray with the empty dishes and glasses.

Shadow Weaver didn't say a word, only watched her leave the room, and brushed her hands down her face.

It was time.

She stood up from bed, walked towards the bookshelf where the little altar had been set up, and picked up the packet of Dhoop sticks. It had a small circlet where the sticks could be put so they would stand vertically to be burnt, and carefully took one out to set it there.

However, when Castaspella was back in the room, the woman was still staring at the packet next to the wooden box. She had yet to light up the stick. She gently placed a hand on Shadow Weaver's shoulder and the woman looked back with a sad smile.

—What?— she sighed.

—Are you ready?

—No…

—Don't you want to do it?

—I don't have the strength…

—May I?— Castaspella gently asked.

—Please…— Shadow Weaver nodded.

With a small smile, she nodded back, took a step forward, drew a small sigil in the air, and activated it with a subtle movement; the Dhoop stick's top lit up brightly for a moment, then went out, and began giving out a fragrant smoke.

—There we go…

—Thank you, Es.

—Anytime, my Love— Castaspella confidently replied, tiptoeing to kiss her.

With that little symbolic gesture, the women honored the memory of Shadow, the little black cat, and silently stared at the altar they had set up, just holding each other tightly for a while…

End Notes

So, on Friday 28th, July, I lost my cat, Magia. I got her ashes more than a week later, and put up this small altar for her:



Now, I wrote this as a final goodbye, trying to put into words the amount of tears I've shed, albeit alone when no one could see me.
I would have loved to have someone like Castaspella by my side but, unfortunately, both my partners live too far away…
And the bit with Madam Razz was my way of fictionalizing a little conversation with my aunt, who wrote a beautiful poem-like text for Magia.
Then, the bit about the whisker is based on the fact that I did in fact save one of her whiskers long, long ago, not in my wallet tho, and wanted to include that here. I know it sounds strange, but it's not as strange as it would be to, I don't know, save hairs or nails. In my opinion, ofc. I saved the whisker because it resembles needles a lot, which I found funny, so I put it on my door with some tape… ~~Why am I telling you this?~~

And the fact that this is part 9 of this Path… It's like this *had* to be a special fic… (9 is basically my number because of the date and time I was born… literally all results in 9)

In the end, I just think I'll keep pouring my heart into my writing and try to keep on moving forward.

Thanks everyone for reading and I hope you could enjoy!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!